

Μένιππος ὁ Γαδαρεύς

Menippus of Gadara on Cynic Law

eul_aid: ibq

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)

Domain: Κωμωδία [Comedy](#)

Format: Ἐπιστολή [Epistle](#)

Menippus of Gadara was a Cynic philosopher and satirist active in the first half of the 3rd century BCE. Ancient sources describe him as beginning life as a slave, later purchasing his freedom, and eventually losing a fortune through moneylending. He earned the nickname "the jesting philosopher" for employing humor to communicate serious Cynic doctrines.

None of his own writings survive complete. He was a prolific author known only through the titles and descriptions preserved by later writers. Works such as **Nekyia**, depicting a descent to the underworld, and **Sale of Diogenes** indicate he used parody to critique philosophical pretension and social conventions. His signature innovation was blending prose with verse, creating a new literary form.

His principal significance lies in founding the genre that bears his name: Menippean satire. This form is characterized by its mixed prose-and-verse format, fantastical scenarios, and philosophical critique. His model deeply influenced later Roman literature. The Roman scholar Varro explicitly imitated him, and his style is considered a direct precursor to major works like Lucian's dialogues and Petronius's **Satyricon**. Through these channels, the Menippean tradition helped shape the development of European satire.

Works (1)

- Ἀπόσπασμα περὶ Κυνικοῦ Νόμου · [Fragments on Cynic Law](#) · 2 passages